What To & Not to Ask in an Interview

Asking questions in an interview is crucial as it not only shows your interest in the position and the company but also helps you gather information to determine if the job is the right fit for you. However, it's important to ask the right questions to leave a positive impression and avoid potential pitfalls. Here's a detailed guide on what to ask and what to avoid during an interview.

What To Ask in an Interview:

1. Role-Specific Questions:

Example: "Can you describe a typical day in this role?"
Why: This helps you understand the daily responsibilities and expectations, ensuring they align with your skills and interests.

Example: "What are the immediate projects or tasks that need to be addressed?"
Why: This shows you are eager to contribute right away and helps you understand the priorities of the role.

2. Team and Company Culture:

Example: "Can you tell me more about the team I will be working with?"
Why: Understanding the team dynamics can help you gauge if you will fit in well.

Example: "How would you describe the company culture?"
Why: This helps you determine if the company's values and work environment align with your personal preferences.

3. Development and Progression:

Example: "What opportunities for professional development does the company offer?"
Why: Shows you are interested in growth and long-term commitment.

Example: "What career paths have others generally followed after starting in this position?"
Why: Gives you an idea of potential career progression within the company.

4. Future Prospects:

Example: "What are the company's goals for the next five years?"
Why: Demonstrates your interest in the company's future and how you might contribute to it.

Example: "Are there any upcoming projects or products that the company is particularly excited about?"
Why: Shows you are interested in the company's growth and innovation.

5. Feedback and Performance:

Example: "How is feedback typically given here?"
Why: Helps you understand the communication style and performance review process.

Example: "What are the performance expectations for this role during the first six months?"
Why: Clarifies what success looks like in the early stages of the job.

What Not to Ask in an Interview

1. Compensation and Benefits Too Early:

Example: "How much does this position pay?"
Why: Asking about salary and benefits too early can make it seem like you are only interested in the money, rather than the role itself. Wait until the employer brings it up or until you receive a job offer.

Example: "What are the vacation days and sick leave policies?"
Why: This can be discussed once an offer is made. Asking too soon might give the impression that you are more interested in time off than the job.

2. Too Personal:

Example: "Do you often hang out with your coworkers after work?"
Why: Personal questions can make the interviewer uncomfortable and are often irrelevant to your ability to perform the job.

Example: "Are you married or do you have children?"
Why: These questions are inappropriate and can be seen as intrusive.

Negative Questions:

Example: "Why did the last person in this role leave?"
Why: This can be perceived as negative or intrusive. Instead, ask about the turnover rate in a more general sense.

Example: "What do you dislike about working here?"
Why: This can put the interviewer in an awkward position and is unlikely to yield useful information.

Too General:

Example: "What does your company do?"
Why: This indicates a lack of research and genuine interest in the company.

Example: "What are the work hours?"

Why: This information is often available in the job description or can be discussed later in the process.

Self-Serving Questions:

Example: "Can I work from home?"
Why: Asking about flexibility before understanding the job requirements can make it seem like you are looking for convenience rather than the right fit.

Example: "Will I get promoted quickly?"
Why: This can make it seem like you are only interested in climbing the ladder quickly, rather than contributing to the role.

Legal or Contractual Details Prematurely:

Example: "Do you offer contract or freelance positions instead of full-time roles?"
Why: These specifics can be discussed later in the interview process or during negotiations if an offer is made.

Example: "Can I delay my start date for a few months?"
Why: This is best discussed after an offer is made and might make you seem uninterested in starting immediately.

Conclusion
Asking the right questions in an interview can set you apart from other candidates and help you make an informed decision about whether the job and company are right for you. Focus on questions that demonstrate your interest in the role, the team, and the company's future, while avoiding those that may appear self-serving or premature. Being prepared with thoughtful questions can leave a positive impression and enhance your chances of landing the job.